With no delimiting metacharacters, the parser would assign everything after the first = assignment to a single var1 parameter. Tread carefully and only encode the values, not the entire query string – the best way is to use http_build_query().

Hopefully you'll now know how to transform a query string into structured data and vice versa, and you'll understand what percent encoding (url encoding) is for. The above example should serve as a simple demonstration that URI reserved characters are reserved for a reason! Hopefully you will also appreciate that http_build_query() can be used to construct POST data strings, because the formatting rules are identical (remember that POST data strings have a media type of application/x-www-form-urlencoded and so should always be percent encoded).

PHP also offers some functions for doing your "manual" percent encoding: urlencode()/urldecode() and rawurlencode()/rawurldecode(). The difference between urlencode() and rawurlencode() is simply how spaces are handled:

```
print urlencode('cat=jess the cat') . PHP_EOL;
print rawurlencode('cat=jess the cat');
```

```
Output:
cat%3Djess+the+cat
cat%3Djess%20the%20cat
```

By default, http_build_query() will encode spaces as +, but it can switch to the other method via its encoding_type parameter:

```
print http_build_query(
    data: [
        'cat' => 'Jess the cat',
        'human' => 'Anna the human'
    ],
    arg_separator: '&',
    encoding_type: PHP_QUERY_RFC3986
);
```

```
Output:
cat=Jess%20the%20cat&human=Anna%20the%20human
```